

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1997-03-30

To all National Spiritual Assemblies in Africa

dear bahá'í friends,

ever since the launching of the four year plan, the universal house of justice has noted, with deep satisfaction, the manner in which bahá'í institutions and communities of the African continent have welcomed the spirit and letter of the broad lines of activity set forth in the plan, and have particularly taken to heart its riḡván message for 153 b.e. to the followers of bahá'u'lláh in Africa. As a supplement to that message, the universal house of justice wishes to convey the following comments to your National Spiritual Assemblies, and through you, to the body of believers in that continent.

The development of the teaching work in Africa has always been characterized by the receptiveness with which the truths of the revelation of bahá'u'lláh have been accepted and valued by the peoples of that vast continent, by the joy stemming from the pure hearts of the African believers as reflected in their radiant faces, and by their growing maturity in appreciating the importance of adherence to bahá'í laws and ordinances.

one of these ordinances is the clear prohibition in the writings of bahá'u'lláh of the consumption of alcoholic drinks. This has been explicitly revealed in his most holy book, the kitáb-i-Aqdas. he states, "it is inadmissible that man, who hath been endowed with reason, should consume that which stealeth it away. Nay, rather it behooveth him to comport himself in a manner worthy of the human station, and not in accordance with the misdeeds of every heedless and wavering soul."

247-1 in other Tablets, we read

from his glorious pen, "beware lest ye exchange the wine of god for your own wine, for it will stupefy your minds, and turn your faces away from the countenance of god, the All-glorious, the peerless, the inaccessible.

Approach it not, for it hath been forbidden unto you by the behest of god, the exalted, the Almighty."

247-2

247-1. kA, ¶119.

247-2. kA, Notes, no. 144.247 .1

247 .2

247 .3

m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

566'Abdu'l-b ahá, adding his voice to that of the blessed beauty, has written,

“The drinking of wine is, according to the text of the most holy book, forbidden; for it is the cause of chronic diseases, weakeneth the nerves, and consumeth the mind.”247-3 he has also written, “r egarding the use of liquor: according to the text of the book of Aqdas, both light and strong drinks are prohibited.”247-4 he further states, “i ntellect and the faculty of comprehension are god’s gifts whereby man is distinguished from other animals. will a wise man want to lose this light in the darkness of intoxication? No, by god!”247-5

in answer to questions, Shoghi effendi’s elucidations, written on his behalf, provide further guidance on this subject. in these letters the habit of drinking is described as a “great misery” and a “great evil.”

it was the policy of Shoghi effendi, upheld by the house of justice, that, in the early stages of the teaching work in countries whose people have for centuries been accustomed to the use of alcohol, the institutions should be

patient and lenient, educate the friends, and allow time for them to extricate themselves from this pernicious habit before applying sanctions. This education has been an ongoing process. regretfully, however, it has been seen that

in some cases, even among certain prominent believers, the friends have not freed themselves from this practice. Some may have wrongly thought that light alcoholic drinks, if taken irregularly, were permitted, without real-

izing the detrimental effect that their example was having on others. it is always most unfortunate when bahá’ís of long standing, and even members of institutions at the national level, partake of alcoholic beverages, thus damaging themselves, harming the good name of the faith in the eyes of non-b ahá’ís, and setting a bad example for the rank and file of the believers. ment of the cause of god in those communities where there remains any doubt among the friends as to the importance of obedience to this law,

that the National Spiritual Assemblies ensure that all believers are clearly informed of it. of course, the Assemblies should not pry into the lives of individual believers; but in the case of any bahá'í who blatantly violates the law, he should be counseled, assisted to overcome the habit, warned repeat-
247-3. Adj, ¶49.

247-4. lg, no. 1171.247-5. cc 2:1790.247 .4

247 .5

247 .6

247 .7

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567edly of the consequences of continued disobedience, and ultimately, if he does not respond positively, be deprived of his administrative rights.

furthermore, in order to protect the interests of the faith, the universal house of justice has decided that, henceforth, any believer who occupies a bahá'í administrative or teaching position on the national level and is seen to be consuming alcoholic beverages, should not only be counseled but should be removed from office during the process of the correction of his failing. if he does not give up drinking, he should lose his administrative rights; if he

changes his ways, and the National Assembly is satisfied that he is obeying the law, he would regain his full rights. The positions the house of justice

has in mind are those occupied by members of the National Spiritual As-sembly or any committee under its aegis, whether national or regional, by bahá'ís who serve at the national office or in the training institutes at any

level, and by traveling teachers and pioneers serving under the direction of the National Assembly or its subsidiary agencies.

it is the hope of the house of justice that such a step will give a signal to the entire community that, whatever the inherited cultural practices or tribal customs may be, every effort should be made by each conscientious believer to obey the sacred law of god which forbids the drinking of alcohol.

The friends must become aware that there are certain essentials of bahá'í conduct that they cannot continue to disregard with impunity. continued,

blatant disobedience to this law will, in the case of any believer, lead to consideration of deprivation of his voting rights. The friends should also realize that refusing to comply with this requirement will not only harm the

offender and injure his family but will certainly impede his spiritual devel-

opment and lead to the cessation of the confirmations of bahá'u'lláh—confirmations and blessings without which his life will eventually be brought down to misery. love for god is best exemplified not through words, but through deeds.

“let deeds,” bahá'u'lláh says, “not words, be your adorning.”

247-6 by obeying

his laws we demonstrate our love for him. he has also written: “m y love is my stronghold; he that entereth therein is safe and secure, and he that turneth away shall surely stray and perish.”247-7

247-6. hw , persian, no. 5.

247-7 . hw , Arabic, no. 9.247 .8

247 .9

247 .10

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568The guideline that Shoghi effendi gave at the outset of the Ten year crusade, setting forth the manner in which the bahá'í law on the need to abstain from alcoholic drinks should be explained while teaching the faith to the people of Africa, is as applicable today as it was in 1953 when the guardian's secretary gave the following advice on his behalf:

The question of impressing upon the Africans who are seeking enrollment the necessity of not drinking is a delicate one. when enrolling new believers, we must be wise and gentle, and not place so many obstacles in their way that they feel it impossible to accept the faith. on the other hand, once accorded membership in the community of the followers of bahá'u'lláh, it must be brought home to them that they are expected to live up to his Teachings, and to show forth the signs of a noble character in conformity with his laws. This can often be done gradually, after the new believer is enrolled.

every effort should thus be made by the institutions of the faith, as well as by those who are directly engaged in the expansion and consolidation work, to make conscious and determined efforts to assist the new believers to realize the grave consequences of disobedience to god's laws, and to appreciate the bounties that flow from growing spiritually under the shadow of h is holy cause.

the Sacred Threshold, that you may be guided in the stewardship of your community as you strive to promote the vital interests of the faith.

with loving bahá'í greetings,

for Department of the Secretariat

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Message to the Iranian Believers—

March/April 1997

Bahá 154 B.E.

To the lovers of the most great beauty, beloved and faithful friends,

The tremendous forces latent in the inmost reality of this precious faith

exert daily a fresh influence in the contingent world and shine forth with greater intensity. Through the outpourings of bahá'u'lláh's bounties, and as 247 .11

247 .12

247 .13

247 .14

248.1

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569a result of dictates of the time as well as the mighty efforts exerted by the followers of his beauty, the faith's life-giving Teachings are taking root in

the world of being, increasing its prestige and manifesting evermore its power to solve the problems confronting humanity. The blessed divine Tree, we

must know, is firmly rooted in the ground, while its branches and offshoots are growing heavenward. All this has been possible through the interaction

and cooperation of two mighty, dominant forces which, in compliance with

god's will, are at work simultaneously, enabling the blessed Tree to grow, put

forth its leaves and blossoms and, at the appointed time, offer to humankind its choicest fruits. one of the generating powers of this spiritual springtime is

tempestuous and soul-stirring in nature; causing lightning and thunder, high winds, torrential rain, and roaring floods. These in turn cause the orchards and fields to become verdant and fruitful. The other is the inherent capac-

ity for growth latent in the blessed seed. it is this capacity that causes the

seed to grow as an essential necessity. The rays of the Sun of Truth and the

sprinklings of the cloud of bounty help it to grow and become a mighty and fruit-bearing tree, providing a celestial retreat for the guided birds of the field.

The overall divine design which leads humanity to spiritual maturity is not within our control; it is well guarded in god's hidden treasure house and its

realization is dependent on his will. ‘Abdu’l-b ahá says:

in this wondrous Age, at this time when the Ancient beauty, the most great Name, bearing unnumbered gifts, hath risen above the horizon of the world, the word of god hath infused such awesome power into the inmost essence of humankind that he hath stripped men’s human qualities of all effect, and hath, with his all-conquering might, unified the peoples in a vast sea of oneness.

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The duty of the people of bahá is to tread the path of servitude to the divine Threshold, it is to spread god’s Teachings and establish a spiritual civilization. praised be god, the loved ones of god throughout the world have, for such a long time, hearkened to the directives of the center of the cause and, guided by the divinely ordained institutions of the faith and according to specific plans, have advanced step by step to hoist the

248-1. Sw Ab, no. 7 .2.248.1a

248.2

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570 banner of the most great Name in every corner of the globe. The last in the chain of systematic successes achieved was the Three year plan which ended last riṣvân and produced heartwarming results. during those three years twelve new National Spiritual Assemblies were established, raising the number of National Assemblies to 174. Also, during that short span of time a considerable number of bahá’ís, like unto a gentle breeze, passed through other countries and lands, engaging in the spreading of divine fragrances, enlisting a number of new believers under the banner of the cause of bahá’u’lláh, and deepening their understanding of the tenets of the faith. These achievements paved the way for the formulation of the present four year plan which outlines the duties of the people of bahá to the end of the twentieth century and mobilizes them to forge ahead and accelerate the process of fulfillment of divine prophecies. These teaching plans, which have successively set the worldwide bahá’í community on the move and broadened the boundaries of the faith, are the product of the creative power of ‘Abdu’l-b ahá’s Tablets of the divine plan. over eighty years ago he summoned the followers of the Abhá beauty to the spiritual

conquest of the planet and gave them this responsibility. Thus, the teaching plans will continue until the golden Age.

The collective duty and responsibility of the believers during the next four years has been spelled out in our last riḡván message and the new plan's prominent features explained. The believers have subsequently been actively engaged in carrying out its provisions. The focus of the present message is the iranian bahá'ís, who, when the dawn of guidance broke,

turned their faces to the Sun of Truth and like unto birds of the dawn sang the songs of welcome and allegiance to him, taking the joyful tiding of

reunion to the people of every land in accordance with this celestial melody:

Announce unto yourselves the joyful tidings: "he who is the best-beloved is come! he hath crowned himself with the glory of god's revelation, and hath unlocked to the face of men the doors of his ancient paradise." let all eyes rejoice, and let every ear be gladdened, for now is the time to gaze on his beauty, now is the fit time to hear-ken to his voice. proclaim unto every longing lover: "behold, your well-beloved hath come among men!"

248-2

248-2. gwb, no. 151.1.248.3

248.3a

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571The iranian believers were not content just with spreading the divine call; they rallied around the promised one and arose to render him assistance in whatever way they could. life in hand and rank upon rank they hastened to the field of martyrdom. The memory of their sacrifices has been perpetuated by the Supreme pen. The account of their heroism is too vivid in the minds of those of us who are the physical and spiritual offspring of such valiant and intoxicated lovers of the blessed beauty to need repetition here. Suffice it to say that we need be on our guard to preserve with our life the inestimable bounty bestowed upon us, lest ingratitude snatch the honor from our hands. The historical background which has conferred upon the friends from bahá'u'lláh's land the privilege of being the first to believe in him and made them distinct in many respects has focused upon them the attention of bahá'ís all over the world. furthermore, in recent times when the gallant

believers in the cradle of the faith were again persecuted by the people of malice, they defended, protected and proclaimed the cause of god with the shield of detachment, reliance on god, heroism and certitude. This redoubled the degree of the worldwide bahá'í community's expectation of the iranian bahá'ís who are scattered throughout the free world. They must, therefore, emulate the example of those lions of the field of steadfastness and learn from them the lesson of servitude. consider the time when the tempest of ordeals started to blow in iran again, how the spark of belief in the hearts of the members of the community, dormant in some cases under the ashes of worldly attachments, suddenly turned into a brilliant flame and wiped out the dust of complacency and heedlessness. The warning sound of the thunderbolt of events awakened them. They became mindful and, in the joyful gathering place of nearness to god, drank the brimful chalice of calamity. oblivious of self, they laid down their heads at the feet of the best beloved. They faced depredation and dismissal from jobs with aloofness and detachment from worldly goods. when the relentless enemy leveled false, trumped-up charges against them to justify their evil doings, with a godly demeanor and heavenly behavior the friends frustrated the adversaries' designs and demonstrated the absurdity of their accusations, thereby proving their innocence in the eyes of broad-minded iranians. The people of malice deprived the bahá'í youth in iran of higher education. The youth, however, did not sit idle. They busied themselves with the acquisition of human perfections. They endured every discomfort and persevered until in the realm of knowledge they excelled their peers. The attainment of this high

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572station and honor became possible when the friends in iran, old and young, women and men, even very young children, realized that the remedy of all their ills was the remembrance of god. They started to study the writings regularly and systematically. it was through their study that the outpourings of the holy Spirit, enshrined in every word of the Sacred writings, came to their assistance and made of that community a new creation in whose eye the world and whatever it contains is worth nothing when compared with servitude to the divine Threshold, attainment of bahá'u'lláh's good pleasure and eternal life in every one of god's worlds. Therefore, they patterned their

lives on the life-giving Teachings contained in the Sacred writings. consequently, they became the glory of this world and of the next, succeeding in promulgating the cause of god in the far corners of the world and among the highest institutions of humankind.

The beloved friends from iran who are scattered throughout the free world must never forget the grave responsibility they bear. for, the expectant eye of everyone is turned towards them, waiting to behold in the mirror of their deeds the splendors of god's Teachings. consider the beloved guardian's appeal to those dear friends:

. . . the beloved friends and members of the Assemblies should, in the manifold circumstances of their lives and in all their multifarious dealings and pursuits, by their deeds, their bearing and demeanor, seek to demonstrate to their fellow-countrymen the excellence of this sacred cause, to vindicate its truth, and give living testimony to its potency and the sublimity of its spirit. it is thus that the friends should proceed, not confining themselves to the delivery of the message, to explanations, expositions and elucidations. 'Abdu'l-bahá, the chief interpreter of the faith of bahá'u'lláh, has written: " wherefore it is incumbent upon all bahá'ís to ponder this very delicate and vital matter in their hearts, that, unlike other religions, they may not content themselves with the noise, the clamor, the hollowness of religious doctrine. Nay, rather, they should exemplify in every aspect of their lives those attributes and virtues that are born of god and should arise to distinguish themselves by their goodly behavior. They should justify their claim to be bahá'ís by deeds and not by name. he is a true bahá'í who strives by day and by night to progress and advance along the path of human endeavor, whose most cherished desire is so to live and act as to enrich and illuminate the world, whose source of

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57inspiration is the essence of divine virtue, whose aim in life is so to conduct himself as to be the cause of infinite progress. only when he attains unto such perfect gifts can it be said of him that he is a true bahá'í. for in this holy dispensation, the crowning glory of bygone ages and cycles, true faith is no mere acknowledgement of the unity of god, but rather the living of a life that will manifest all the perfections

and virtues implied in such belief." See how firm and strongly-worded is this statement of 'Abdu'l-bahá's, and how demanding its require-

ments! Notwithstanding, it is only when the bahá'ís are able fully and befittingly to distinguish their characters by the adornment of these divine virtues that they will appear before the eyes of the world in a worthy and appropriate manner and that the name of bahá'u'lláh will set the universe ablaze. The chosen ones of god in iran should not

look at the depraved condition of the society in which they live, nor at the evidences of moral degradation and frivolous conduct which the people around them display. They should not content themselves merely with relative distinction and excellence. rather they should fix

their gaze upon nobler heights by setting the counsels and exhortations of the pen of glory as their supreme goal. Then it will be readily

realized how numerous are the stages that still remain to be traversed and how far off the desired goal lies—a goal which is none other than

exemplifying heavenly morals and virtues. Therefore, as the treaders

of the path of salvation, we should strive with all our might and in every moment of our life to vindicate by deeds and words the reviv-

ing power enshrined in bahá'u'lláh's Teachings. in our association and

conversation with others, in our transactions, performance of duties,

our aims, and in major and minor undertakings we should so appear as to proclaim and prove to all that other than the unifying power of

bahá'u'lláh's Spirit nothing can transform the hearts of people and

make of them a new race of men. This is the only means for the salva-

tion and victory of the cause of god.

The lovers of the blessed beauty in iran, assisted by the promise which

says, "This is the only means for the salvation and victory of the cause of

god," saw clearly how astonished the enemies were when they witnessed the

fortitude of the friends under trials and their deeds which complied completely with divine exhortations. it was such behavior that turned strangers

into friends and supporters of the wronged ones. it is certain that tests are

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57not confined to the iranian friends; the ordeals which confront the believ-

ers in the free world, although different in nature, will be as severe and

deceitful. if they do not face such tests with the aid of a prayerful attitude

and constant engagement in service, they are likely to be submerged in the

ocean of bewilderment, confusion and remorse, wasting away the short days of their lives and leaving this world with empty hands. of particular

importance is the training of the youth to enable them to stand firm against the perils of the society in which they live. They should be encouraged to participate in bahá'í activities, while pursuing their education in fields

which benefit humanity.

bahá'u'lláh says:

whosoever attaineth divine love at the earliest stages of youth, that one is accounted among the dwellers of the highest paradise. Strive that from thee mayest appear that which will cause the exaltation of the faith.

Also:

o thou who art young in age! may the confirmations of the merciful enable thee to attain unto his bountiful bestowals. Since thou wert adorned with the recognition of the daystar of revelation when thou wert in the prime of youth, beseech thou god to enable thee to achieve that which will be immortalized in the book of existence. mortality overtaketh everything except what is uttered and carried out for god's sake; such [words and deeds] are deathless. Strive that thou mayest drink of the wine of immortality and attain unto the kawthar of steadfastness."

we ardently hope that bahá'í youth who have their roots in the cradle of the faith will, in all affairs, stand out among their peers. The youth who received bahá'í education have, undoubtedly, reached the stage when they can fend for themselves and face the tempestuous tests of the present day world with valor, confidence and self-assurance. The bahá'í youth who have distinguished themselves and stood out in the non-bahá'í world are a testimony to the truth of this statement.

The persecuted bahá'ís of iran are deprived of the bounty of teaching the cause of god. The effect of this deprivation, which they regret immensely, 248.7a

248.7b

248.8

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575 is mitigated when they hear that friends in other countries are carrying out teaching work on their behalf, or have arisen to execute a project in their name or in the name of the precious martyrs of that land. Such glad tidings prompt the Iranian friends to offer loving prayers for the success of the efforts of their faithful comrades in other parts of the world. We now join our eager voice to that of these Iranian believers and appeal to the friends from Bahá'u'lláh's birthplace in every part of the globe to arise in accordance with the requirement of faithfulness and make mighty and effective efforts to teach the cause of God on behalf of their long-suffering brothers and sisters. For, teaching the faith is a spiritual obligation from which no one is exempt; it is the magnet that attracts divine confirmations, it is the cause of the revival of hearts and souls. The Supreme Pen says:

center your energies in the propagation of the faith of God. Whoso is worthy of so high a calling, let him arise and promote it. Whoso is unable, it is his duty to appoint him who will, in his stead, proclaim this revelation, whose power hath caused the foundations of the mightiest structures to quake, every mountain to be crushed into dust, and every soul to be dumbfounded.

248-3

he also says:

in one of the Tablets this exalted word hath been revealed from the Supreme Pen: "Whoso is unable to teach should appoint a deputy." Praised be God, this munificent banquet is now spread for the enjoyment of all. The four year plan provides guidance to each and every one involved with the achievement of the teaching goals. In some cases, when people are unable to directly teach the cause, they have been exhorted to deputize someone to carry out this duty on their behalf. Should they be unable to deputize one person, they can, in accordance with their financial ability, make contributions earmarked for deputization through local, national, continental and international funds of the faith. In brief, all means have been provided for everyone to participate in the teaching work which, according to 'Abdu'l-Bahá, is the foremost duty, leaving no room for any

248-3. gwb, no. 96.3.248.9a

248.9b

248.10

576excuse. moreover, the people of the world who are weary and helpless in the face of present-day ordeals are more than ever ready to embrace the cause of god. failure to take advantage of this opportunity would indeed be a grave loss, for it would deprive the aching body of humanity of a remedy placed freely in the hands of the people of bahá. This is the day on which, according to ‘Abdu’l-b ahá, “The cry of ‘where are bahá’í teachers’ is raised from every corner of the world. . . .” blessed are the ones who have hearkened and responded with heart and soul. This appeal is particularly significant these days because, according to the four year plan, in the concluding years of this century the number of teachers should so increase as to hasten the entry of troops under the shadow of god’s cause. The dearly loved iranian believers, wherever they reside, must not deprive themselves of the bounty of participation in bahá’í activities. They should rather arise unitedly with the native friends and join forces with them to offer befitting service under the direction of bahá’í institutions. Nay, they should even take the lead and become renowned in servitude to the d ivine Threshold.

Another matter of great import which the iranian believers cannot afford to neglect is the instruction of children in spiritual attributes, human perfections and heavenly character. in this, too, they can learn from the example of the sacrificial friends of iran who train their children from infancy under their loving care, adorn them with the ornaments of a praiseworthy character, and help them to advance in the acquisition of knowledge and understanding of spiritual truths, thus exemplifying this exhortation from ‘Abdu’l-b ahá: . . . exert every effort to educate the children, so that from infancy they will be trained in bahá’í conduct and the ways of god, and will, even as young plants, thrive and flourish in the soft-flowing waters that are the counsels and admonitions of the b lessed b eauty.

248-4

Also:

it is incumbent upon bahá’í children to surpass other children in the acquisition of sciences and arts, for they have been cradled in the grace of god.

248-4. Sw Ab, no. 97 .2.248.11

248.11a

248.11b

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577whatever other children learn in a year, let bahá'í children learn in a month.248-5

And again:

while the children are yet in their infancy feed them from the breast of heavenly grace, foster them in the cradle of all excellence, rear them in the embrace of bounty. give them the advantage of every useful kind of knowledge. let them share in every new and rare and wondrous craft and art. bring them up to work and strive, and accustom them to hardship.

248-6

consider carefully the following statement revealed by the pen of the Ancient beauty:

The parents must exert every effort to rear their offspring to be religious, for should the children not attain this greatest of adornments, they will not obey their parents, which in a certain sense means that

they will not obey god. indeed, such children will show no consideration to anyone, and will do exactly as they please.

248-7

Nowadays in many countries people are rebellious and careless, morally corrupt and afflicted with various problems. At a time like this, obedience to the above ordinances is more vital than ever before. The friends in iran have successfully put these ordinances to work and learned through experience that one of the immediate results of this endeavor is to empower their precious children at an early age to confront difficulties in school, on the street and in the market-place and to show forth heroism, thereby preserving their integrity and safeguarding the reputation of the faith. The friends in other parts of the world should do likewise. for, should the children be deprived of a spiritual foundation, their protection from the onslaught of destructive temptations will be compromised.

one of the laudable services which the iranian bahá'ís everywhere can pledge to perform is initiating work on establishing character training classes

248-5. Sw Ab, no. 119.1–2.

248-6. Sw Ab, no. 102.3.

248-7 .lg, no. 763. 248.11c

248.11d

248.12

248.13

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578for children and rendering assistance in maintaining them. Those friends who were the pupils of these classes and have enjoyed the sweetness of the fruits of such education should actively participate in this great service, which is the cause of strengthening every bahá'í community, and provide for children's bahá'í education everywhere.

furthermore, the bahá'í parents from iranian background should endeavor to teach their children the persian language, for persian is one of the two languages of revelation in this glorious dispensation. bahá'u'lláh says:

“in this day when the Sun of knowledge hath appeared and is resplendent from the firmament of iran, it is fitting to praise this language as much as one can.” he also says: “The desire of the world speaks in the persian language. it would be praiseworthy to him, if his loved ones also converse and write in this language.”

it would be a great service if, in every city and hamlet where a number of iranian bahá'ís reside, some persian friends would exert special effort to teach this language to the children and youth, study together the writings in persian, and drink their fill from the billowing source of the creative word and Sacred writings. we praise god for having enabled some bahá'í institutions abroad to devise ways and develop programs useful for teaching the persian language to those iranians who live away from their homeland. Such programs can be put to good use for the achievement of this blessed service.

The valued friends of iran have always been and continue to be at the forefront in rendering worthy services to the cause of god. we need not review the record of sacrifices made in the arena of faithfulness by the heroes of the Apostolic Age. A careful look at the early stages of the formative Age will enlighten us about the historic and crucial services of the iranian believers in glorifying the cause of god and its establishment throughout the world, and will evoke our admiration and praise. in the Ten year plan,

which the beloved guardian called the world Spiritual crusade, a considerable number of iranian bahá'ís succeeded in opening up countries and territories to the light of the faith. The names of these knights have been recorded in the roll of honor. Also, numerous are those who have contributed generously to the establishment of essential and significant institutions. recently, when monetary donations for the construction of buildings on the Arc became a necessity, the iranian friends living abroad considered it unbecoming to lag behind others. As before, they stepped forth with high endeavor and participated as much as possible in providing the financial needs of those mighty institutions.^{248.14}

248.15

248.16

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579o friends of god, it is certain that the cloud of divine bounty and bestowal rains equally upon all humanity. however, we each partake of it according to our capacity. Although potentialities differ in accordance with degrees, not a single soul is completely bereft of capacity. indeed, people's progress in this world is dependent on that preordained measure and the manner in which they fulfill their god-given potentiality. Accordingly, our responsibility is commensurate with our capacity, as it is said: "g od will not burden any soul beyond its capacity." it is our ardent hope that the lifelong lovers of the divine beauty will, in the privacy of their conscience and in the presence of god, thoroughly assess their ability, judge their situation, and decide what kind and extent of service they can render in the path of the love of bahá'u'lláh, then offer it in fulfillment of a vow of faithfulness, that they may attain the bounty of reunion in the everlasting world and reap the harvest of their existence. otherwise, if they think only of their own comfort in this mortal life and be heedless of the purpose of creation, undoubtedly they will bring loss and regret upon themselves. 'Abdu'l-b ahá says:

of what benefit to humanity is the body's comfort which consists of the night's rest, the day's talk, the gathering of provisions in the morning, enjoyment of the fireplace in the evening, and the pleasure of a highly comfortable and extravagant bed made of finest silk and brocade! A considerable time is wasted in idle talk. once it comes to an end, it is loss upon loss and manifest perdition.

how penetrating is bahá'u'lláh's utterance which exhorts his faithful servants thus:

Night hath succeeded day, and day hath succeeded night, and the hours and moments of your lives have come and gone, and yet none of you hath, for one instant, consented to detach himself from that which perisheth. bestir yourselves, that the brief moments that are still yours may not be dissipated and lost. even as the swiftness of lightning your days shall pass, and your bodies shall be laid to rest beneath a canopy of dust. what can ye then achieve? how can ye atone for your past failure?

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248-8. gwb, no. 151.4.248.17

248.17a

248.17b

m e S a g e s f r o m T h e u n i v e r s a l h o u s e o f j u s t i c e
580o beloved and faithful friends from the land of bahá'u'lláh's birth! our longing, nay our hope and expectation of those valued friends is this: that in obedience to divine commandments and exhortations, you become like unto morning stars, shining from the horizon of guidance and leading the way, thereby attaining unto that which the peerless beloved has desired and ordained for you.

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Riḍván Message 1997

Riḍván 154

To the bahá'ís of the world

dearly loved friends,

we acclaim with grateful hearts the eager response on all continents to the four year plan launched last riḍván.

consultations of the continental counselors and National Spiritual

Assemblies started an extensive planning process, also involving Auxiliary board members and local Spiritual Assemblies. Through such a process the

national and regional character of the derivative plans took shape. but this

world-encompassing exercise did more than yield distinctive schemes for the different countries; it also boosted the collaborative relationship of the two arms of the Administrative

order, a most welcome portent of the victories yet to come.

A sign of the immediate impact of the plan was the speed with which steps were taken to establish nearly two hundred training institutes during the last twelve months. many of these have gone far beyond the point of designing their organization; they are actually in operation and have offered their first courses. moreover, in the movement of homefront and international pioneers and traveling teachers; in the increased attention given by individuals to deputizing teachers; in the preparations made to ensure the formation of local Spiritual Assemblies only on the first day of riḡván; in the increasing endeavors to hold regular devotional meetings; in the widening efforts to make use of the arts in the teaching work and community activities—in all these respects could be discerned the friends' keen awareness of the importance of concentrating on the requirements of the major 248.18

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581aim of the plan, which is to effect a significant advance in the process of entry by troops.

Nor can we neglect to recognize other developments during the past year which confirmed the high merit of the manifold efforts being exerted by our world community and the results being achieved. Among these, to mention a few, were: the acquisition of the apartment at 4 Avenue de camoëns in paris where the beloved master, 'Abdu'l-b ahá, resided during his historic visit to the city; the special session on 14 August of the federal chamber of deputies in brazil to mark the 75th anniversary of the introduction of the bahá'í faith into that country—a unique, official occasion at which Amatu'l-b ahá rúḡyyih khánúm was present as the honored guest; the launching last july of the bahá'í international community's site on the world wide web, entitled "The bahá'í world," which to date has received from more than 90 countries and territories over 50,000 visits, averaging some 200 per day. hardly outpaced by such accomplishments, the construction projects on mount carmel maintained a dazzling momentum highlighted by the

completion of the marble colonnade of the center for the Study of the Texts, by the rise of the international Teaching center building towards its seventh level, and by the ongoing emergence of the far-stretching features of the Terraces of the Shrine of the báb. in this connection must be mentioned the partial lowering of the section of the public road over which the line of terraces will pass, and the acquisition and subsequent demolition of the building at the foot of the mountain which stood as the last obstruction that had to be overcome to make possible the completion of the lower terraces through which the glorious pathway rises up towards the sacred edifice and beyond it to the crest of the hill of gold.

Also of acute relevance to the progress thus described was the maintenance of a level of contributions to the Arc projects fund which fulfilled the goal for the last year. clearly, the financial demands in this regard are being met with incessant heroism by rich and poor alike, and must be sustained over the remaining years. At the same time, however, a parallel effort, equally strenuous and sustained, should be simultaneously exerted by the Assemblies and friends throughout the world to fill the critical needs of the bahá'í international fund.

Such an auspicious beginning to the four year plan as has been experienced cannot but inspire confidence in the hearts of the members of our

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message from The Universal House of Justice

582worldwide community that they are fully equipped to execute its requirements as outlined in the messages that launched it, and as elaborated in the plans adopted by their respective Assemblies. A further and especially appreciated encouragement as we enter this second year is that circumstances have made it feasible for the reestablishment this riḥván of the National Spiritual Assembly of Rwanda. This victory over crisis will bring to 175 the number of National Spiritual Assemblies that will be eligible to participate in the eighth international bahá'í convention to be held next riḥván at the bahá'í world center. how dearly we hope that by then, at the very midpoint of the plan, the bahá'í world will have made a major leap forward in the multiplication of its human resources, the maturation of its Spiritual Assemblies, and the evolution of its local communities!

The opportunity offered by the brief span of time before the century ends is precious beyond all telling. only a united and sustained effort by the friends everywhere to advance the process of entry by troops can be-fit such a historic moment. responsibilities urgent and inescapable press upon every institution, every member of a community striving towards its god-promised destiny. As there is only a short period in which to achieve a great deal, no time must be spared, no opportunity lost. rest assured, dear friends, that the hosts of the Abhá kingdom stand ready to rush to the support of anyone who will arise to offer his or her acts of service to the unfolding, spiritual drama of these momentous days.

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Formation of Regional Bahá'í Councils

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]